



Understanding Your Dog's Stress Bucket

The bath tub analogy — why calm dogs suddenly can't cope

Every dog carries a kind of internal **bath tub** that fills up with stress. This idea comes from veterinary behaviourist **Dr Sarah Heath**, whose bath tub (or “stress bucket”) analogy helps explain why a dog can seem perfectly fine one moment and overwhelmed the next.



It fills up

Everyday events each add a little water



It overflows

A full tub spills over — the reaction we see



It drains

Rest & recovery let the water drain away

The bath tub

Imagine a bath tub. Throughout the day, everyday events — a doorbell, a car journey, an unfamiliar dog, an exciting visitor — each pour a little water in. On their own, none of these fills the tub. But they add up.

When it overflows

When the water reaches the top, it spills over. That overflow is what we see as a reaction: barking, lunging, freezing, or shutting down. The dog isn't “being naughty” — the tub is simply full.

The plug hole

Crucially, the tub also has a plug hole that lets water drain away. Rest, sleep, sniffing, gentle enrichment and calm recovery time all help the water drain, lowering the level so there's room again.

Why it matters

A dog with a nearly-full tub has almost no capacity left to cope. Keeping the level low, and allowing time to drain, is one of the kindest things you can do for your dog.

What this means for you

- A dog that reacts strongly may have been filling up all day.
- Several small stressors can matter as much as one big one.
- Recovery time between events isn't optional — it's how the tub empties.
- Keeping the level low makes your dog calmer and better able to cope.